

MAN-MADE? Flooded streets of Ankleshwar, Bharuch district, Sept. 19

KALPESH GURJAR

war Dam and the Indira Sagar Project (ISP) Dam—were opened by September 14-15," his statement read. "Experienced engineers of the Sardar Sarovar Narmada Nigam Ltd (SSNNL) should have anticipated this by September 7, further confirmed by September 14 looking at the ongoing rains. They should also have been able to draw an estimate of when this water would reach SSP. If the government had started opening the gates of SSP, gradually releasing water periodically, this calamity could have been avoided," the statement said. Vyas, a water management expert who headed the Narmada Water Resources Department as cabinet minister, says the precise data of when dam gates are opened and the corresponding flow of water is available in real time to SSNNL engineers and also updated live on its website. However, this data, Vyas alleges, had not been uploaded on the website after September 6.

The state government has refuted every allegation, denying any wrongdoing on SSNNL's part. It laid the blame instead on a "cloudburst" between ISP and SSP on September 15 and 16, causing a "flash flood" on September 17. "Rainfall figures recorded at rain gauge stations upstream of SSP from September 5 to 14 indicate low to very low rainfall. There was no significant forecast by the Central Water Commission (CWC) or release by the ISP and thus no reason to release water from SSP on September 13, 14 and 15. The catchment area of SSP received moderate rainfall on September 15 and a cloudburst happened between ISP and SSP on September 16 and 17. ISP was full and started releasing all the water downstream to SSP. On September 16, at 11 am, the maximum flow recorded at SSP was 2.2 million cusecs [the dam's discharge capacity is 3.1 million cusecs]. SSP started releasing 45,000 cusecs downstream on September 16 at 10 am, 100,000 cusecs at 12 pm, 500,000 cusecs at 2 pm and 800,000 cusecs at 5 pm. Some 1.9 million cusecs were released in the early morning of September 17," a detailed statement by SSNNL read, adding that the data too was made available on the website.

Questions are also being raised about the SSNNL's decision to stop operations of the River Bed Power House (RBPH)—one of the two hydel generation units—on September 6. The RBPH generates power by using the force of water, which then flows out to the sea. Had the RBPH been functioning, that much water would have flowed down. SSNNL maintains that there was no rain throughout August. "In the Sardar Sarovar Reservoir Regulation Committee (SSRRC) meeting of Narmada Control Authority (NCA) on August 1, it was decided that the SSP level of water on September 4 should be 136.64 metres while the actual level at SSP was 133.73 metres on that day. Hence, it was decided to shut down the RBPH between September 6 and 16," the SSNNL statement says.

THE ABRUPT RELEASE OF 1.9 MILLION CUSECS OF WATER FROM THE NARMADA DAM CAUSED THE FLASH FLOODS

Vyas as well as multiple water experts have contested the clarifications. M.S.H. Sheikh, senior environment activist and president, Surat-based Brackish Water Research Centre, has urged the CM to reject SSNNL's clarification and conduct an impartial inquiry. "No incident of cloudburst has been reported by the IMD. The CWC forecast figures don't match with the SSNNL statement. There was a forecast of heavy rain in catchment areas and dams upstream were at full reservoir level (FRL). Both warning signs were ignored," Sheikh said in his letter. Gujarat's largest farmers' body, the Khedut Ekta Manch, has also demanded action against the guilty.

Though the SSNNL has countered the allegations, there is discomfort in the government regarding the incident. "Looking at the weather forecast, NCA had advised to restart RBPH on September 7 itself. It is not clear why it was not done and water was hoarded. With the weather forecast and the FRL data of the upstream dam, SSP could have started releasing water on September 14 and 15. This wouldn't have affected the CM's event on Sunday morning. It is unclear why these decisions were taken," says an SSNNL source, not wanting to be named.

Anger ran high in the affected districts. A video of Kunvarji Halpati, minister of state for tribal and rural development, labour and employment, and Bharuch BJP MLA Ramesh Mistry leaving an affected area in Bharuch town after being cornered by people went viral on social media. A man seen expressing his angst at the losses and also dragging in the CM and PM Modi, was booked for "defaming and scolding constitutionally appointed leaders". The allegations are serious as they expose the perils of the control dam managers enjoy, and the damage human decisions can cause—be it an error of judgement, negligence or an act of political expediency. ■